

Mumbai

- Twin cross-runways mean only one can be used at a time
- No land for building a third runway
- Capacity of 14 million passengers. Now handles 25.8 million.

Chennai

- No standby radars. Instruments that measure visual range at the runway often go out of action.
- Capacity of 7.7 million passengers which is expected to go up to 12 million this year

Hyderabad

- Long queues at immigration counters. It can take over 30 minutes to get clearance and over an hour to recover baggage.
- Queues force aircraft to wait on tarmac, blocking take-off slots

Amritsar

- New terminal was already obsolete when it opened in 2006 with 55 per cent growth in passenger traffic
- Construction work has added to space crunch. Passengers have to walk through debris.

lays at the end of the day and this causes a cascading effect down the line," says an official of the Directorate General of Civil Aviation (DGCA), the regulatory body for civil aviation. The hope is that matters may improve after the new airports are ready. Not so fast. Space may be redone, say, by developers like GMR and GVK but critical functions where investment in manpower and technology is a must are still with the Government. So technically you could still be stuck at the immigration counters or circling the outer ring road waiting for a slot to land.

Immigration counters, the single biggest bottlenecks at international airports, are the responsibility of MHA. "If all the counters are manned at peak hours, queues can come down by 25 per cent," says an airline official. With the ministry moving at a pachydermal pace, passengers are unlikely to get any relief in the short term. "Congestion could actually slow down this sector," warns Mark D. Martin, senior adviser with KPMG India. "There seems to be no urgency on the part of the Government to speed up airport infrastructure development," he adds. The Airports Authority of India (AAI), which controls aviation and air traffic services, has clearly prospered on the aviation boom, with annual revenues of over

MANDAR DEODHAR



GROWTH PANGS: Renovation has left passengers stranded at the Mumbai airport

because it employs advanced landing and take-off technology and advanced navigation systems.

At the Chennai International Airport, rated one of the best and safest in the country, ATC officials say landing safety is an issue. The airport apparently got second

Rs 3,000 crore coming from landing, parking and air traffic control fees. But it has not invested in crucial aviation infrastructure like air traffic control systems, say airline officials. Thanks to the socialist pattern of cross subsidy, this money goes to maintaining smaller airports, some of which have no flights. Thanks to this, the ones which make money suffer. Consider Mumbai airport. Its historically-flawed cross runway means that at any given point, only one runway is operational. As a result, the airport can manage only 27 movements per hour, while an airport like Gatwick in London, which also has one runway, handles over 60 movements per hour

-hand radar equipment in 1998. "Usually radars have a life of a decade as per rules, but here we have been using second-hand equipment for more than 10 years. It goes offline very often," says an ATC official. The airport does not have standby radars and its transmissometer that measures the visual range is reported to often fail. Because of this, air traffic

A P RABHAKARRAO



TEETHING TROUBLES AT NEW AIRPORTS

Narayan and his family had to walk nearly 700 metres, at the new Hyderabad airport, with their bags to the car park.

"We took longer to clear arrivals than board at Kolkata."

P.K. NARAYAN
MD, JUMBO MINING